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Describe the cause and effect of urbanisation

Cities have become the default home of humanity. Over half of the world's population are already living in urban areas, with the share forecast to climb to 68% by 2050, meaning that another 2.5 billion people will move into cities within three decades (UN-Habitat, 2022). Such a scale of movement has never been seen before. It has been driven by the pull of city jobs, together with the hardships that push farmers away from the countryside, while its consequences now reach the economy, the environment and the health of billions of residents. Therefore, this essay explores the causes of urbanisation driven by the concentration of jobs in cities and rural hardship, discusses how cities concentrate wealth and opportunity, and examines why uncontrolled urban growth overwhelms housing and public services.

Firstly, jobs piling up in cities is a key cause of urbanisation. Young people in the villages can rarely find work that fits what they studied, because the factories, companies and universities all sit in the cities, where the roads and the customers are. A wage earner in the city, as the World Bank (2021) has counted, commonly brings home two or even three times what the same job pays in the village, a gap which gives village youth a strong push towards the cities. Additionally, farm machines have been eating steadily into the need for field workers. One combine harvester, in a single harvest season, can do the work of dozens of people, with the villagers it displaces drifting naturally towards the cities to look for wages.

Secondly, hardship in the countryside, from poverty and conflict to the slow damage of the land, drives residents away from their villages. In countries torn by years of conflict, such as Syria and South Sudan, whole villages and their farmland have gone up in smoke,

forcing millions of families onto the road, with most ending up in cities rather than in refugee camps (UNHCR, 2022). Meanwhile, farming has become an increasingly hard living across parts of Africa and South Asia, weakened by soil erosion, drought and river pollution. Therefore, many migrants aspire to settle permanently in cities and give their children access to schools and hospitals that their home regions cannot provide, resulting in a steady increase in urban populations. These two pressures, together, are why the cities never stop growing.

Coming to the effects, urbanisation also puts real money into the economy. Cities, by packing workers, money and know-how into a small area, allow people to split the work and help each other in ways that scattered villages could never manage. City regions, by the common estimates, churn out over 80% of the world's GDP while sitting on less than 3% of its land (UN-Habitat, 2022). Those who reach the cities usually earn more, learn more and choose from more careers, with the money they post home propping up the villages and towns they came from. For instance, remittances sent home by overseas workers and city residents have become a major source of household income in countries like the Philippines, running into tens of billions of dollars each year (World Bank, 2023).

Nevertheless, uncontrolled urban growth puts heavy pressure on housing and public services. More than one billion people currently live in slum districts or self-built housing without safe tap water, proper drains or a legal address, and the figure keeps rising in fast-growing cities of Africa and Asia (UN-Habitat, 2022). The influx of the newcomers also dilutes medical and educational resources, resulting in classrooms packed with students, roads jammed at all hours and hospitals without enough hands. Air pollution

from traffic and factories further weakens residents' lungs over the years, with city air pollution blamed for millions of early deaths every year (WHO, 2022). Cities like Mumbai and Cairo, for example, have waited decades for their informal districts to be upgraded, with families raising children on unpaved lanes (UN-Habitat, 2022). The pursuit of a better life thus turns, for the poorest newcomers, into a threat to health itself.

In conclusion, urbanisation is primarily driven by the concentration of jobs in cities and by the hardships of rural life. It concentrates wealth and opportunity, lifting the productivity of entire nations, but it also places a significant strain, one that keeps growing, on housing, services and the environment. Despite these concerns, urbanisation itself is not the problem, and the lack of planning is. Governments should therefore invest in secondary cities and rural infrastructure, spreading opportunity more evenly across each country's territory, so that moving to the city becomes a choice rather than a necessity. Planning, in short, decides whether the city turns out to be a ladder or a trap.

Word count: 777

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